Problem Solving

1. Define the problem precisely

Most failed projects solved the wrong problem well. Turn a vague brief into one **key question** that is specific, measurable, action-oriented, relevant and time-bound.

- Weak: 'How can we improve our stores?'
- Strong: 'How can we raise like-for-like store profit by 10% within 18 months without cutting service scores?'
- **Problem statement worksheet**: key question · context · success criteria · scope (in **and out**) · constraints · stakeholders · sources of insight

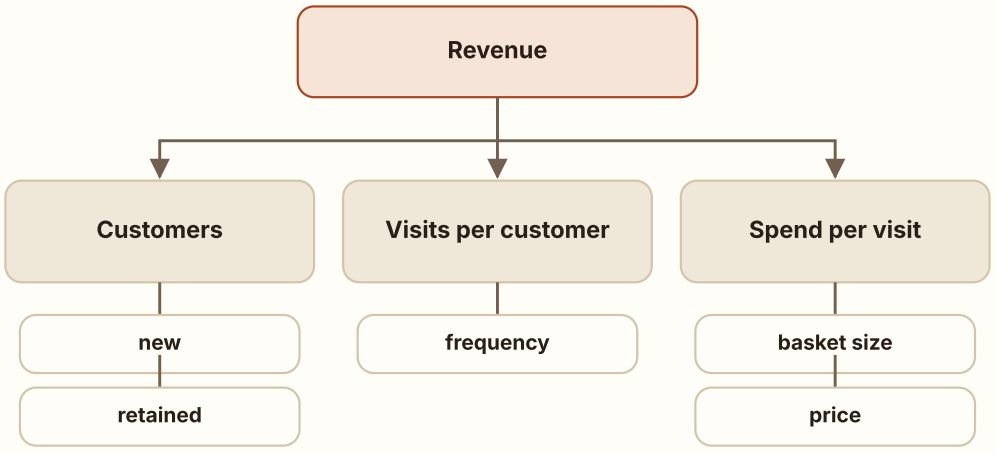
2. SCQ framing

- **Situation**: the stable context everyone agrees with
- **Complication**: what changed or what's wrong
- **Question**: what we must answer as a result
- 'We've led the regional market for a decade (S). A low-cost entrant took 6 points of share in a year (C). How do we respond to protect profit (Q)?'

3. Issue trees

- **Diagnostic** (why is this happening?) · **Solution** (what could we do?) · **Deductive** (what does this equal? e.g. revenue = customers × visits × spend per visit)
- Deductive trees are the most powerful: if the maths holds, they're MECE by construction
- Test MECE: could a fact fall in two branches? Is any cause left out? Go 3 to 4 levels deep, until each leaf is one analysis

✎ DIAGRAM



A deductive tree is MECE by construction.

4. Hypothesis-driven work

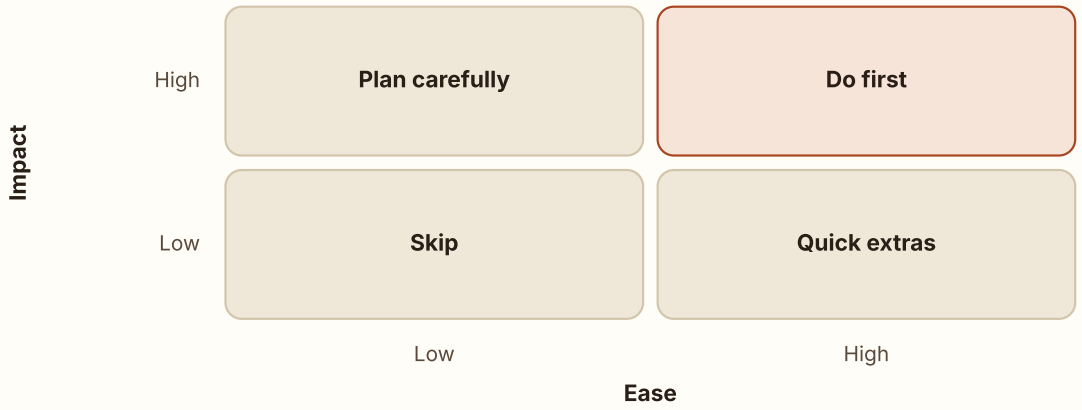
- Restate branches as claims: 'profit fell mainly because input costs rose', supported by 'bean prices rose 20%' and 'we didn't pass costs to price'
- **Day-1 answer**: a best guess at the final recommendation, written on day one, revised as evidence arrives
- **Ghost deck**: the final slide titles drafted on day one with empty charts, to show what must be proven

5. Prioritise and plan

- **80/20**: a few branches hold most of the value · **impact × ease** · 'could any result of this analysis change the decision?'
- **Workplan**: one row per hypothesis: analysis · data source · owner · due date · end product
- Every analysis ends in a **so-what**: 'labour is 30% of cost' is a fact; 'we overstaff mornings by 15%' is a so-what

> ⚠ Don't boil the ocean. Hypothesis first, then the minimum data to test it.

✎ DIAGRAM



Prioritise analyses and options by impact and ease.

SAY IT

"My Day-1 answer is X. Here's the analysis that would prove or kill it, and here's the ghost deck of what we'd need to show."